



metroPLUS

THE HINDU



Madras Art Guild transforms a mall into a gallery spotlighting sustainability **P3**

INSIDE INDIA'S LARGEST MOTION CAPTURE STUDIO **P4**



Hold your horses
(Clockwise from far left) A Triumph car; vintage watches; classic scooters; and Srinivasan Kasyap, founder of Roaring Riders Club. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Sanjana Ganesh
sanjana.g@thehindu.co.in

It all began with a Mustang dream. Years before he could get his hands on the vehicle, Zubin Songadwala, a senior operations manager in hospitality, says that his mentors fuelled his desire to own a vintage car. One that was effortlessly classy. “Who doesn’t want a lady like this,” says Zubin, standing next to his slick yellow 1972 Ford Mustang Mach 1 that he purchased in 2015. At a recent first time collaborative meet up between the Roaring Riders Club car and the Madras Watch Collectors Group, the Mustang effortlessly

The hands of time

Collectors of vintage cars, bikes and watches share the secret to ensuring that their toys keep humming over the decades

steals the show. Participants line up to take pictures with the car and peer in through the windows. “Beauty,” they whisper softly to themselves. Here, enthusiasts of bikes, cars, and watches, the finer things in life, have gathered to indulge each other’s passion and discuss the specs of their collection. What began as a spontaneous, quick discussion between Srinivasan Kasyap, a founding member of Roaring Riders Club, and Guru Prasad, part of the Madras Watch Collectors Group, has quickly turned into a meeting with over a 100 folks



geeking out over their favourite form of machine, nay ‘children’, they say. There are over 300 vintage watches, the earliest being 95 years old; over 20 Jawa or Yezdi motorcycles; and just as many vintage cars, on display at the lawn of Green Park hotel in Vadapalani. Now, roaring to life, these machines serve as reminders of needing to remember that everything, including inanimate objects, sometimes come with heartbeats.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 2



60 years of TRUST

GRT
G.R.Thanga Mällgal
JEWELLERS
Since 1964

Swarna Ugadi

₹250*
LESS
PER GRAM ON
GOLD JEWELLERY PURCHASE

₹100*
EXTRA
PER GRAM ON
OLD GOLD EXCHANGE

12.5%
OFF*
ON DIAMOND
& UNCUT DIAMOND VALUE
(EXCEPT SOLITAIRES)

25%
OFF*
ON WASTAGE (VA) FOR
SILVER ARTICLES

10%
OFF*
ON MRP FOR
SILVER JEWELLERY

This offer is not applicable on purchase of Gold coins/bars. Limited period offer. Conditions apply.

Tamil Nadu | Puducherry | Andhra Pradesh | Telangana | Karnataka || Singapore

Shop online at: grtjewels.com | Shop from the comfort of your home | 1800 203 1000 / 1800 599 1515 | Follow us: | Store Locator

An exhibition, **Shakti: Threads of Female Power**, aims to explore femininity beyond the labels of divinity at Alliance Française of Madras

Drawing from strength

Sanjana Ganesh
sanjana.g@thehindu.co.in

Shakti, the feminine, lends itself to several interpretations across the subcontinent. French artist Marielle Maury, a fashion designer whose practice is rooted in sustainability and artisanal production, says that she did not know what it meant when she first encountered it, but had a hunch. “Shakti is a humble, unexplainable, yet powerful intelligence. Even if I don’t believe in any religion, I was convinced that it had to do with feminism,” she says. Marielle is part of a cohort of five artists from Germany, France, and India who took part in a residency starting September in Chennai that introduced the said artists to regional textiles and other traditions. A collaboration between Goethe-Institut Chennai and Alliance Française Madras, this residency will now culminate in an exhibition titled Shakti: Threads of Female Power, at Alliance Française of Madras. The exhibition will interpret textile through installations and

art work across the campus. The participating artists include Anna Cambier from France, Bettina Mileta from Germany, Marielle Maury, and Munira Nizam Diwan and Sanskruti Shukla from India.

Patricia Théry-Hart, director, Alliance Française of Madras, and Katharina Gorgen, director, Goethe-Institut Chennai, say that the idea came from their own love for Indian textile. That it nearly

coincides with Women’s Day, is entirely intentional, they say. When they both took charge of their offices during their posting in India, they were captivated by the colours. As the two directors get ready to bid the country good-bye and move elsewhere for their posting, they decided to put their heads together to formulate the idea for this exhibition. “Our aim was to highlight two key dimensions: women and craftsmanship, specifically textiles in Tamil Nadu,” says Patricia. The exhibition put together by curator Kalyani Pramod, a

Chennai-based artist and founder, Common Threads Studio, “brings the collective gaze of women, ever watchful, unifying, and amplifying our voices,” she adds. Berlin-based artist Bettina Mileta says that her work will explore this gaze through large textile installations in outdoor spaces. “The piece will be constructed out of multiple panels in colours that loosely refer to Madras Checks all handmade of silk and sewn together in a double stitched seam,” she says. Bettina is intent on deconstructing this connection of working with fabric and its inherent ‘indoor’ nature. “Women were expected to stay at home, to do the duties of the house and occupy themselves with hobbies such as embroidery. My interest is to see how this can be framed in a different world,” she says. Other artists like Sanskruti will use wool and silk to explore material sensitivity, while Munira Nizam Diwan examines the subtle negotiations women make between social expectations and personal desires. There will also be three workshops focussing on Indian textiles, including a weaving workshop inspired by the jamakalam by Aslii Thari; a natural dyeing workshop by ColorAshram; and Stamp your Truth workshop by Ruchi and Verena. What kind of shakti are you? Time to find out this weekend.

@AF Madras, Nungambakkam, March 7, 11am. Registration for the workshops is mandatory and is priced at ₹300.

Women at the helm

Founded in 2024 by Maithreye Rajagopal, the Honest Hustle Collective returns with its third edition, spotlighting women-backed enterprises and organisations where women are not beneficiaries but producers and decision-makers. “I am bringing together enterprises rooted in sustainability, dignity of labour and measurable grassroots impact, with the backing of the community,” says Maithreye. She describes the Honest Hustle Collective as more than a marketplace — it is a platform for purposeful partnerships and measurable change. Over 28 brands from across the country will showcase their work. Colour Ashram, from Ahmedabad, will be offering a natural dye workshop for participants aged 15 and above. ReCharka will travel to Chennai with handwoven lifestyle products made from discarded plastic waste, crafted by rural women who transform environmental challenges into circular design solutions. Check out Chennai-based Smith Design Studio,

known for bridging traditional craft and contemporary design through naturally dyed yarns and Diti’s sustainable clothing. The MG Gramodyog Sewa Sansthan Foundation will showcase its revival of Bengal muslin, featuring hand-spun and handwoven indigenous cotton fabrics. Textile reviver, Pankaja Sethi, who collaborates closely with loom clusters across Odisha, will be showcasing her collection along with Tula, the brand that champions rain-fed organic cotton and khadi, working closely with farmers to promote soil health and climate-resilient textiles. Adding a dimension of women’s wellbeing, Martin’s Mocktails will present a curated wellness menu featuring fresh juices and salad bowls.

Chitradeepa Anantharam

@Alliance Française of Madras, Nungambakkam, March 7 and 8, 12pm to 8pm. Entry is free. For details, call 9629850007



Her story Five artists interpret textile through installations and art work. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

When walls have eyes

French street artist Kashink brings her feminist, improvisational style to Chennai with her four-eyed murals



Leaving a mark The mural at Alliance Française of Madras by French artist Kashink. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Sangita Rajan
sangitarajan.pb@thehindu.co.in

The Alliance Française of Madras is getting a mural on its walls as a part of the fifth edition of Wall Art India.

The initiative, led by the Alliance Française network in collaboration with the Embassy of France in India and the Institut Français, is bringing international and Indian street artists into neighbourhoods.

In Chennai, the spotlight falls on French street artist Kashink, whose bold, four-eyed figures are known across the global urban art circuit for their unapologetic feminist voice.

Perched on scaffolding at the Nungambakkam campus, she is painting a monumental portrait that draws from the cosmic force of shakti.

“I’ve been in India for a little more than two weeks now,” says Kashink, who has already painted in Chandigarh and Kolkata. While this edition centres on women’s empowerment, she notes that her work has always carried a feminist undercurrent. “I’ve been painting murals for the past 20 years, always with this type of feminist approach. Back then, it

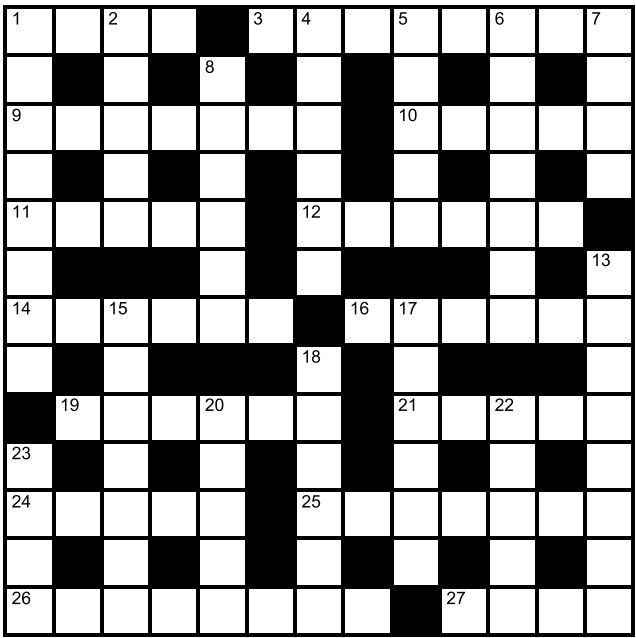
wasn’t really addressed publicly that much. It’s great now that’s changed.” Her characters, instantly recognisable, bold and almost mythic, are imaginary figures rendered in striking colour. They often carry a message directed towards women and oppressed minorities.

The figure she is painting at Alliance Française de Madras carries her signature four eyes. “The two pairs can express two different feelings, and that’s exactly who I am,” she says.

Shakti, she admits, is not a concept she grew up with. “Where I’m from, it doesn’t really exist. So it was important for me to listen to what people here were saying about shakti.” Conversations about the many forms of feminine energy of goddesses, colour symbolism, and divine power began shaping the mural’s direction. The mural took her three days to complete.

“I picked her because she illustrates the new generation of young women who are powerful and fighting. It’s very strong and colourful at the same time. She does not paint for art’s sake. It’s meaningful and bold,” says Patricia Théry-Hart, director, Alliance Française de Madras.

QUICK CROSSWORD #43 (Set by Doppelganger)



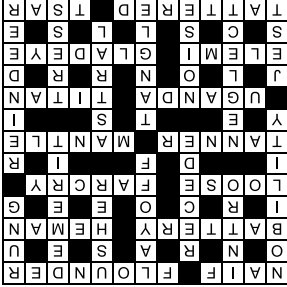
- Across**
- 1 Inexperienced person (4)
 - 3 Struggle clumsily (8)
 - 9 Artillery unit (7)
 - 10 Muscular person (2-3)
 - 11 Not tight (5)
 - 12 Extensive (3,3)
 - 14 He converts hide to leather (6)
 - 16 Cloak (6)
 - 19 African country (6)
 - 21 Saturn’s satellite (5)
 - 24 Oily resin (5)
 - 25 Seductive glance (4,3)
 - 26 Ragged (8)
 - 27 Emperor of Russia (4)
 - Down**
 - 1 Distinguished by high rank (8)
 - 2 Beginning (5)
 - 4 Fire (6)
 - 5 Escort (5)
 - 6 Black mark (7)
 - 7 Degree in heirarchy (4)
 - 8 Move back (6)

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.



- 13 They pull Santa’s sleigh (8)
- 15 Disregard (7)
- 17 Stellar (6)
- 18 Intertwine (6)
- 20 Din (5)
- 22 Pigtail (5)
- 23 Prank (4)

Solution No. 43



CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

Collectors who have held onto their pieces for years tell us the secret to ensuring that their cars, bikes, and watches keep running. Zubin says that there are two ways to look at a vintage car. “One could either be a purist and maintain the vehicle just as it came out of the factory. But if you want it to run just like it does on the road, modifications become essential,” he says. Speaking alongside Sudhir Natarajan who owns an orange Mustang, the duo says that rebuilding classics require changes to the battery, wiring, fuel pumps, wheels, and the engine. “This car does not have a coolant and in a city like Chennai, a coolant is of essence. We also changed the size of the wheels which were originally 14 inches to become 15 inches so that they could ride effortlessly,” says Zubin. It is of essence to romanticise this relationship

The hands of time

because Zubin does it casually. He says that vintage cars must be treated as ‘mature’, not ‘old’ ladies. “You cannot drive these pieces recklessly on the road. Inside it, there is no air conditioner, no bluetooth speaker, no music. It is, in essence, old,” he says. What then brings him back to the Mustang. “On weekdays full of meetings and things, I come back tired. On Sundays, when I take my Mustang out, I am one with the car. Suddenly, the rest of the world disappears,” he says. Sudhir, who has been in the automotive space for years now, says that at the moment, there are 35 vintage and classic cars at his shed owned by various people, waiting for repairs. They all

seem to echo the same emotion. “Customers treat these pieces like family so when the restoration happens, it becomes an emotional experience,” he says. Guru from the Madras Watch Collectors Group seems to echo a similar sentiment. Some months ago, an acquaintance on Instagram had posted about a Seiko 5 watch from the 1980s that stopped running. “I offered to reach out to my network, provided a ‘donor’ watch from which parts could be used. My friends helped fix it.



(Clockwise from left) Zubin Songadwala and Sudhir Natarajan with their Mustangs; a vintage jeep; a Harley Davidson bike. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

When the person got the watch, he had tears in his eyes. His mother cried too. Turns out that the watch belonged to his father who had recently passed. I couldn’t control myself too and shed a little tear of joy with them. That is the kind of impact watches have. They may not be as expensive as the rest of the machines here today but they are important markers in a person’s life,” he says. Horologist Dinesh Sachdev whose family has been in horology for four generations now, and three from a post-Partition India, runs Time World in Chennai. He says that literally any watch in the world can be fixed with time and money. “One needs ample patience to ensure that there is enough time to work on broken pieces, and all the money to ensure that we fashion the parts to customise it. A recent Rolex Bubble Back took seven to eight months to fix,” he says. He shows off his own watch, a 95-year-old silver pocket watch with customised straps that once belonged to his grandfather. Srinivasan, who runs

Roaring Riders, is interested in the world of watches too. During the event, you could see him flitting from one booth to the next, striking up a conversation about everyone’s passion. Srin, as he is called, says that he is intent on having more such meetings where people ardently speak about all that they love with joy. His active group of riders drive Yezdi motorcycles exclusively and enjoy going on long trips once in two weeks besides meeting on the first Sunday of each month at Ashoka Hotel in Egmore. Maintenance of bikes come with customisations too. Zubin and Srin speak about needing the right amount of space, and the right parts. During some rides, Srin says that he carries spares and tools in case the bike stops. What then is this nostalgia that hooks him? “Look at my bike. How cool is it. Rajini has said in an interview that he loves the Yezdi and has one too. I’m sure it’s lying around somewhere,” he says, adding that his father owned one of these bikes too. Two heroes. What better reason to indulge in a passion? What better reason to claim nostalgia.



Priyamedha Dutta
priyamedha.dutta@thehindu.co.in

The entrance to Anna Nagar's VR Mall is decked up with a huge installation. From a distance, it looks like a selfie spot drawing visitors in. But step closer and the work reveals something far more sobering, something deeply tied to a crisis that is constantly being talked about in the news. Titled *The Portals*, the installation is made from 180 kilograms of discarded plastic waste collected from beaches across Chennai.

Conceptualised by artists King Gowtham, M Elanchezheyam, M Gowtham, and B Pugazhendhi, it is one of the many striking works presented at the fifth edition of the Madras Art Guild, organised in association with Yuj Foundation and in collaboration with UNESCO, with sustainability at the heart of its vision.

Inaugurated on February 12, the art festival has transformed the shopping mall into a living gallery. Titled *Future is Now*, this year's edition showcases over 1,300 works spanning paintings, photographs, installations, and sculptures. Participating institutions include the Government Fine Arts College,

The shape of green

Madras Art Guild's Future is Now exhibit showcases over 1,300 paintings, photographs, and installations

Kumbakonam; The Pupil Saveetha Eco School; Cholamandal Artists' Village; Annai Kamakshi Music and Fine Arts College; Ology Tech School-Chitravati Centre for



Creativity; and SA Film Academy under SA Institutions.

Curator Sumi Gupta echoes the spirit of the festival, "What we're essentially trying to say is this: we can't postpone responsibility. We can't tell ourselves that we'll do better in the future, that we'll save the planet someday. If we don't act now, if we don't take care of the earth in the present, there may not be a future left for the next generation."

"We have to urgently rethink how we treat the environment, how we use and embrace technology... the change has to begin now," she further adds. Some installations also take

Chennai in the limelight At Madras Art Guild's exhibition. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

on a participatory form. One such, *Love Piano* by Saravanan Senathipathi, is crafted in collaboration with the Consulate-General of Japan in Chennai and Yamaha. Open to all, it invites passers-by to pause, engage with the keys and create an impromptu melody of their own. Another of his installations, displayed outside the mall and titled *Kala Car*, has also gained a lot of attention. For this piece, he has painted his signature tribal faces on a bright yellow Ambassador, turning the iconic car into a piece of art.

Our city's many facets Photography, too, takes centrestage at the festival. Chennai in Focus, an open call, drew over 2,500 entries from which 100 standout photographs by 84 photographers were selected for display on the wall. The images capture the many facets of Chennai.

The festival also presents a wide range of community-focussed line ups, bringing together traditional street performances, student-led cinema, literary engagements, and a curated Art Bazaar. Spread across several days, it evolves into a dynamic public celebration – featuring puppet traditions, folk performances, and live percussion, alongside film screenings and masterclasses, author interactions and book fairs, as well as handmade crafts and interactive workshops for audiences of all ages.

As visitors move through the installations, performances, and conversations, the festival ultimately transforms a commercial space into a call for collective reflection that the future depends on the choices we make today.

Madras Art Guild is on at VR Mall, Anna Nagar, till March 22. Entry is free.

Three wheels for a cause

British women entrepreneurs are driving from Chennai to Goa in auto-rickshaws to raise funds



Chitradeepa Anantharam
chitradeepa.a@thehindu.co.in

In a bold display of grit and global sisterhood, 35 women entrepreneurs set off on a 1,000-kilometre auto-rickshaw rally from Chennai to Goa. The UK-based The Sisterhood Group, founded in 2006, is once again spearheading the UK Women Entrepreneurs Rally - Let's Goa 2026. The participants are undertaking the journey to combine adventure with advocacy, raising funds and awareness for women and children's empowerment initiatives.

"As the founder of the group, I see this as both a challenging and adventurous experience – and an opportunity to prove that women can endure the toughest situations and emerge victorious," says Emma Sayle, founder, Kensington & Chelsea Group (KK Group), UK.

The rally flagged off from Chennai on March 3. "We learned to drive an auto-rickshaw in just two days, and we've thoroughly enjoyed riding around the city. Now, we are really

Adventure with a purpose The rally aims to mobilise funds for women's development. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

looking forward to the trip," says Frankie James, who runs a publishing firm.

On day one, the participants will reach Vellore. They will travel onward to Bengaluru, Mysuru, Mangaluru and Bhatkal, before finally arriving in Goa on day seven.

"This rally demonstrates how global collaboration can create grassroots impact," says Ulagu Palaniappan, a Circler from Madras Midtown Ladies Circle 7. The 2025 rally raised over ₹1 crore with 52 participants.

Professional tour operator Travel Scientists, oversees the licensing process to manage logistics, safety, and on-road support throughout the rally. The participants typically drive for three hours at a stretch before taking a break.

Supported locally by Madras Midtown Round Table 42 (MMRT42) and Madras Midtown Ladies Circle 7 (MMLC7), the expedition aims to raise between ₹1-3 crores.

Follow updates on the rally on Instagram: @thesisterhoodgroup

A pen in hand

The Chennai Pen Show brings together over 50 exhibitors, apart from global and domestic brands. This is the third edition of the event, with 2025 seeing over 16,000 visitors, according to Aditya Bhansali, the organiser. It will bring together handmade pen makers from across the world, and there will be some industrial brands as well. Names include Ranga Pens, Sheaffer, ST Dupont, Pelikan, and Diplomat, among others, and apart from fountain pens, there will be inks, stationery, and vintage writing instruments for sale.

Aditya explains that there will be an exclusive space for premium selections and attendees can interact with pen makers. Another highlight is vintage pens that are over 125 years old and in working condition. These pens come with a lot of history, and Aditya says that names of previous owners of these pens have been documented. There will be pen makers who are there just to meet fellow pen lovers and share stories.

On from March 6 to 8, 2pm to 7pm, at Fika, Adyar. Prices range from ₹200 to ₹20,00,000. For details, visit chennaipenshow.com



IndianOil

ALL WOMEN CAR RALLY 2026

THE DUCHESS CLUB

Sunday, 8th March, 8am
SAVERA HOTEL

Entry Fee Rs.2000/-
(Inclusive of Lunch for 4)

Registration : 9841288631 / 9710947355
<https://forms.gle/a2nHS4ejHfScFs4R7>

Organised by **fmsci**

World of Women... Over the years!

Co-Sponsor	Prize Sponsor	Protien partner
RAMCO	HEALTHYSTUDIO	epigamia
KAUVERY	A.CUT ABOVE	Hospitality
KIA	CHENNAI BRIDGES	SAVERA
PNCCI	MUTUAL FUND	

146, Dr.Radhakrishnan Salai, Mylapore, Chennai - 600 004



Kerala through the lens

Photographs of Kerala's people, landscapes, wildlife, and culture, offering a cohesive and contemporary portrait of the region, will be on display at Lenscape Kerala, the State Tourism Department's travelling photo exhibition. The Chennai leg of the exhibition, covering 10 cities, will be inaugurated by Malayalam actor Seema and former editorial advisor to *Better Photography* magazine Sadanand Menon, and will showcase a curated collection of 100 images captured across Kerala by 10 photographers from across India.

Curated by art critic Uma Nair, with renowned Nature conservation photographer Balan Madhavan as art director, the show features works by acclaimed photographers H Satish, Shivang Mehta, Amit Pasricha, Saurabh Anand Chatterjee, Saibal Das, Umesh Gogna, Manoj Arora, Aishwarya Sridhar, Natasha Kartar Hemarajani, and Kounteya Sinha.

The exhibition will run until March 7, 11am to 7pm, at Lalit Kala Akademi

Kalpa Druma
An Indian Story

25 - 50%
Storewide Discount

SUPER SALE

5th - 10th March 2026

CRAFTS | HOME TEXTILES | GARMENTS | SARIS
Shopkalpadruma.com

Only in store **CATHEDRAL ROAD**

044 2811 7652
+91 98407 25315

07 MARCH 2026

CHENNAI

ONE LAST TIME

REINDEER INTERNATIONAL SCHOOL

VASANTH & CO
India's No.1 Dealer

HIPHOP TAMIZHA WORLD TOUR
RETURN OF THE DRAGON
The Home Coming Finale

ASSOCIATE SPONSOR: **PGS**
FASHION PARTNER: **TRENDS**
MEDIA PARTNER: **THE HINDU**
ENERGY PARTNER: **ARROW**

YMCA GROUND, CHENNAI

CITY PRIDE PARTNER: **SUPER CHENNAI**
LED PARTNER: **PIXEL ART**
GENEST PARTNER: **FXE**
TRAINING PARTNER: **JK**
SOUND & LIGHT PARTNER: **DDP**
INTEREST PARTNER: **ACT**
INFRASTRUCTURE PARTNER: **CHANDRA**
TICKETING PARTNER: **district**

DOOR PARTNER: **AdOnMo**
OUTDOOR BRANDING PARTNER: **SKYWAYS**
SHOWROOM PARTNER: **ANON**
LOGISTIC PARTNER: **BROWN PIST**
MEDICAL PARTNER: **Be Well**
RADIO PARTNER: **SURYAN**
METRO PARTNER: **WV**
BRANDING & PROMOTION PARTNER: **BANK**
PHOTOGRAPHY PARTNER: **WV**



Motion revolution

Inside India's largest motion capture studio in Hyderabad, where SS Rajamouli shot key sequences for Telugu film *Varanasi*

The butterfly effect

All about the Tamil relationship thriller starring Nivedhithaa Sathish

Bhuvanesh Chandar
bhuvanesh.chandar@thehindu.co.in

What was the last gripping Tamil thriller that you watched at the theatres? If you have to think to answer that question, you are already stating enough about how badly Tamil audiences have been craving for a good thriller. And if the trailer of *Oh Butterfly* is any indication of the film that is awaiting us, our wait may be over soon. Starring Nivedhithaa Sathish, Ciby, Nasser, and Attul among others, the film is set to release in theatres on March 6.

Oh Butterfly is a relationship thriller that follows a newly married couple. "The wife has been hiding a secret from her husband, something she hopes to reveal at the secluded vacation home she takes him to. However, unexpectedly, her ex shows up at the home, and their lives change for good," reads the logline of the film directed by debutant Vijay Ranganathan.

What has particularly caught the eye about the promotions is the film's gripping tale. Nivedhithaa Sathish in a still from *Oh Butterfly*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

well-cut trailer. "There's a lot of unexpected stuff happening in the film, and so we obviously wanted to keep them hidden. But we wanted to show the three distinct characters who anchor the film," says Vijay.

Shot in Kotagiri, Kodaikanal, and Chennai, *Oh Butterfly* also stars Lakshmi Priya Chandramouli and Geetha Kailasam in pivotal roles. With music scored by Vaisakh Somanath, the film has cinematography by Vedaraman Sankaran and editing by Bhuvanesh Manivannan. Director Vijay Ranganathan also produces the film with Vennky, Anand S Shah, and Nisha Patil under the Anthill Cinema and Palampur Talkies banners.



Sangeetha Devi Dundoo
sangeethadevi.k@thehindu.co.in

At the newly-launched A&M MoCap Lab inside Hyderabad's Annapurna Studios, positioned as India's largest and most advanced motion capture facility, an artiste wearing a specialised suit equipped with markers, demonstrates stunt moves. His movements, recorded using high-definition motion tracking cameras, are transferred to 3D computer generated characters.

The data helps filmmakers analyse precision, speed of movement, camera angles and depth required for a live action film shoot. The data, which includes facial capture, also helps animation filmmakers and the gaming sector to deliver characters that mimic life-like expressions.

Motion capture, often referred to as MoCap, facilities are not new to India. Facilities in Bengaluru and Mumbai are often used by the animation and gaming sector. But imagine MoCap as part of pre-production work for a larger-than-life film. Say, a stunt sequence involving 20 to 30



actors or even a war sequence. It involves a larger floorspace, several cameras and supporting software.

For his upcoming Telugu film *Varanasi*, starring Mahesh Babu and Priyanka Chopra

Jonas, director SS Rajamouli used MoCap to plan stunt sequences as part of pre-visualisation work.

The A&M MoCap Lab, though formally unveiled by Rajamouli in late February 2026, has been functional since mid-2025. The lab is a partnership between actor-producer Nagarjuna Akkineni's Annapurna Studios, *Baahubali* producer Shobu Yarlagadda's Mihira Visual Labs and Animatrik Film Design that provided technology solutions to Hollywood films such as *Avengers: EndGame* and *Spider-Man: No Way Home*.

The 60ft x 40ft x 30ft space is equipped with more than 60 Vicon Valkyrie (VK26) high-fidelity motion tracking

cameras, Vicon Live for real-time data streaming, Vicon Post for advanced post-processing, and Unreal Engine live preview that enables interaction between performers and digital environments. The setup includes stereo head-mounted camera units that aid high-resolution facial performance capture.

MoCap technology

For the unversed, pre-visualisation is a part of pre-production work before a film goes on floors. Earlier, hand-drawn images were used to create a storyboard, with the director, action choreographer and cinematographer weighing in on placement and

movement of people and camera equipment.

"We wanted a MoCap space with ample height, depth and scale in India, in Hyderabad," says Shobu. He and Rajamouli had met Brett Ineson, president and CTO of Animatrik Film Design, to understand the feasibility of introducing such a facility in India.

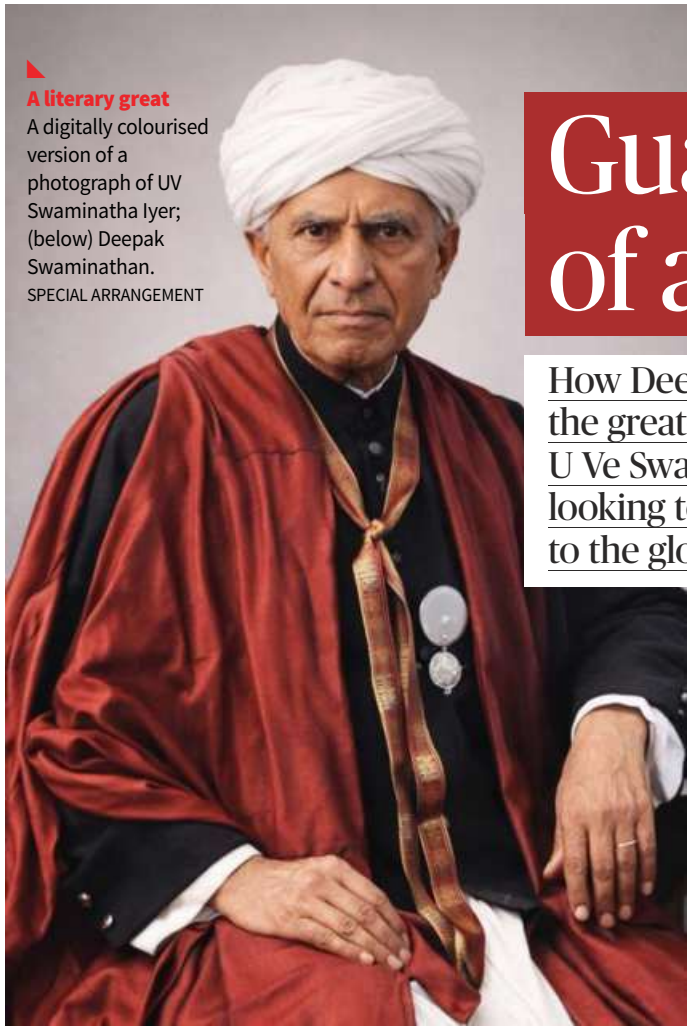
Around the same time, CV Rao was keen to explore newer technology that could be introduced at the Hyderabad studio. Shobu pitched the idea during a casual conversation, after which Rao travelled to LA to meet Brett and understand the technology being used for large-scale motion capture in Hollywood films.

Rao states, "It was going to be a one-time investment and given the vibrant film industries and gaming sector in India, Annapurna Studios decided to go ahead." Shobu's Mihira Visual Labs, launched two years ago to work on animation and visual effects for the animation film *Baahubali - The Eternal War*, partnered on the ambitious project.

Tech leaps since Kochadaiyaan

In the Indian context, moviebuffs may recall the country's first photorealistic motion capture film – Soundarya Rajinikanth's *Kochadaiyaan* (2014). "The film was ahead of its time but the technology was nascent. It was a great experiment. Today such a film can be done with ease," says Shobu.

Closer home in India, Rao and Shobu state that there is curiosity about exploring the technology. He adds, "when cutting-edge technology is available here, more filmmakers are likely to explore it".



A literary great
A digitally coloured version of a photograph of UV Swaminatha Iyer; (below) Deepak Swaminathan. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Guardians of a legacy

How Deepak Swaminathan, the great-great-grandson of U Ve Swaminatha Iyer, is looking to take his Tamil works to the global arena

his mentors and elders," explains Deepak.

For him, the biggest challenge was in the sheer density of the original 195-page text, where each of the 12 stories includes classical poems, narratives and 'story-within-a-story' concepts. To do justice to the material, Deepak even undertook a journey to select locations around Thanjavur, Kumbakonam and Mayuram that are mentioned in the treatise.

Future steps

While the e-book version of *Kandathum Ketadhum* receives positive feedback from the Tamil community – in fact, Chief Minister MK Stalin has sent a letter of appreciation on February 19, 2026, the 171st birth anniversary of U Ve Sa – Deepak's dream is to build a metaverse for Tamizh Thatha.

It will be a "living, breathing digital ecosystem", where users can walk through new-age galleries, participate in gamified quizzes and engage in an e-library where you can not only read Tamil works but also meet experts in real-time to exchange notes and thoughts. He adds, "We hope to create a space where the wisdom of the 20th Century meets the technology of the 21st. My goal is to ensure that Tamizh Thatha's work is not just stored for the future, but is vibrantly experienced by it".



To access the e-book, log on to playtown.co.in

Srinivasa Ramanujam
srinivasa.r@thehindu.co.in

Tamil is a language. But, *Tamizh* is an emotion.

54-year-old Deepak Swaminathan, entrepreneur, start-up mentor and author, knows a thing or two about this. As the great-great-grandson of UV Swaminatha Iyer – fondly called "Tamizh Thatha" by Tamilians across the globe – he comes from a legacy rooted in the preservation of knowledge. Today, armed with over 25 years of experience in the multimedia training and experiential events space, Deepak has embarked on a series of projects to put the spotlight on "Tamizh Thatha".

UV Swaminatha Iyer (1855-1942) is best known for devoting his life to Tamil literature; he travelled across Tamil Nadu collecting palm-leaf manuscripts and saved ancient Tamil literature from destruction. Scholars believe that it is primarily due to his efforts that we still have access to classics

like *Silappathikaram* and *Manimekalai*. "His contribution was as much about 'method' as it was about 'discovery'," describes Deepak, "He pioneered modern textual criticism in Tamil. He spent years cross-referencing multiple versions to ensure accuracy, adding detailed commentaries, and providing historical context."

Deepak's latest work is an illustrated English-Tamil e-book version of *Kandathum Ketadhum*, a 90-year-old treatise of U Ve Sa. Unlike the Sangam manuscripts that he rescued from decaying palm leaves, this work is a collection of personal memoirs and oral histories. "It is a literary treasure that functions as a vibrant social autobiography of the Tamil land. It captures the events he personally witnessed, such as the grand patronage of arts and the discipline of the gurukula system and the stories passed down by

Unfreeze your Shoulder.

Don't "Live With It." Treat It.

Frozen shoulder isn't just pain.

It's the quiet frustration of losing everyday comfort. Getting dressed. Reaching up. Driving. Sleeping through the night.

At Epione Pain Management Centre, Egmore.

we offer advanced, non-surgical care for the shoulder pain, designed to ease pain, improve movement, and help you return to normal life faster

- No hospital admission
- Same-day discharge
- Minimal downtime
- Personalised rehabilitation guidance



76313 76313, 9978171819

No.28 Old No:126, Marshalls Road, Rukmani Lakshmi Pathy Salai, Egmore, Chennai - 600 008, Tamil Nadu
Hyderabad: 95020 20251 | Bengaluru: 90631 16311

Treatment is advised only after clinical evaluation. Results vary based on stage and severity.